This is a policy that Israel routinely employs to hold Palestinians without charge, but almost never uses against Jews. “Of course I would prefer the main tool to be indictments, but if that’s not possible… then I don’t mind the use of other means that the law allows,” he said.

Elazar Stern, a Knesset member from the centrist HaTnuah party, called for similar steps. “The settlement of Yitzhar should be marked as a place which sends out terrorists,” he said, calling for checkpoints at the entrance and army raids at night. The Labor Party’s Omer Bar-Lev went even further, arguing that the “continuous violence” left no choice but to close Yitzhar and evict its residents. “This is a decisive step, but if we don’t act today with determination, this will end with more than tires punctured and policemen lightly injured,” he said.

Any decisions ultimately fell to the cabinet, however, and in particular to the defense minister, Moshe Ya’alon. He was sharply critical of the Yitzhar attack, calling it “terrorism, to all intents and purposes.” But he was also a man of the right, an opponent of Palestinian statehood thought to enjoy good relations with the settler movement (though not for long). Days after closing Od Yosef Chai, Ya’alon allowed settlers to move into a building on the outskirts of Hebron, the first expansion there in decades. “They’re trying to divert attention from the real issue,” Shaul said of the closure in Yitzhar. “It’s a show. The next day they announce a new settlement in Hebron. To close a *yeshiva*, it’s just a stunt.”

About 200 of Yitzhar’s 350 registered voters ultimately turned out for the “referendum” at the end of April, and 97 per cent of them rejected further attacks on soldiers. Yitzhak Ginsburgh, the head of Od Yosef Chai, urged residents to halt the violence. “I am distressed by any clash of Jews on Jews,” he wrote in an article. His decree, and the vote, were respected. The army spent a year in Od Yosef Chai, but would eventually withdraw and allow it to reopen.

Still, it was clear that not everyone was satisfied. A week after the vote, *Yediot Aharonot* published emails from the settlement’s internal mailing list. Several residents defended the attacks on soldiers in remarkably blunt language. “I’m in favor of throwing stones (at the Jews; of course there’s no question about the Arabs) in certain situations,” wrote one 22-year-old woman, “even if the stone brings the death of a soldier.” She would soon be arrested for incitement. “There is no *halachic* problem with killing a soldier